FOR RELEASE AT 8:30 AM EDT, WEDNESDAY, OCTOBER 28, 2026

MONTHLY ADVANCE ECONOMIC INDICATORS REPORT, SEPTEMBER 2026

Release Number: CB26-177

October 28, 2026 — The U.S. Census Bureau announced the following international trade, wholesale inventories, and retail inventories advance statistics for September 2026:

	ADVANCE INTERNATIONAL TRADE: GOODS DEFICIT		ADVANCE WHOLESALE INVENTORIES		ADVANCE RETAIL INVENTORIES	
SEPTEMBER 2026	$134.9 Billion	+2.1%°	$1,011.5 Billion	+0.6%	$885.3 Billion	+0.3%
AUGUST 2026	$132.1 Billion		$1,005.6 Billion (R)		$882.3 Billion (R)	

Next release: November 27, 2026.

* The 90 percent confidence interval includes zero. There is insufficient evidence to conclude that the actual change is different from zero.
° Statistical significance is not applicable or not measurable.
Data adjusted for seasonality but not price changes.
Source: U.S. Census Bureau; Advance Economic Indicators Report, October 28, 2026.

Advance International Trade in Goods

The international trade deficit was $134.9 billion in September, up $2.8 billion from $132.1 billion in August. Exports of goods for September were $209.2 billion, $5.3 billion more than August exports. Imports of goods for September were $344.1 billion, $8.1 billion more than August imports.

Advance Wholesale Inventories

Wholesale inventories for September, adjusted for seasonal variations and trading day differences, but not for price changes, were estimated at an end-of-month level of $1,011.5 billion, up 0.6 percent (±0.2 percent) from August 2026, and were up 7.4 percent (±1.1 percent) from September 2025. The July 2026 to August 2026 percentage change was unrevised from up 0.5 percent (±0.2 percent).

Advance Retail Inventories

Retail inventories for September, adjusted for seasonal variations and trading day differences, but not for price changes, were estimated at an end-of-month level of $885.3 billion, up 0.3 percent (±0.2 percent) from August 2026, and were up 4.8 percent (±0.5 percent) from September 2025. The July 2026 to August 2026 percentage change was revised from the preliminary estimate of up 0.2 percent (±0.2 percent)* to up 0.3 percent (±0.2 percent).

The October 2026 Advance report is scheduled for release on November 27, 2026. View the full schedule in the Economic Briefing Room: < https://www.census.gov/economic-indicators >. The full text and tables of this release can be found at < https://www.census.gov/econ/indicators/index.html >.

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GENERAL INFORMATION

Notice of Revision - Revisions to the Wholesale estimates were released on October 26, 2026 and are reflected in this release. Estimates are revised based on historical corrections and the results of the 2023 and 2024 Annual Integrated Economic Survey.

EXPLANATORY NOTES

International Trade in Goods

Goods (Census Basis)

Data for goods on a Census basis are compiled from the documents collected by the U.S. Customs and Border Protection and reflect the movement of goods between foreign countries and the 50 states, the District of Columbia, Puerto Rico, the U.S. Virgin Islands, and U.S. Foreign Trade Zones. They include government and non-government shipments of goods and exclude shipments between the United States and its territories and possessions; transactions with U.S. military, diplomatic, and consular installations abroad; U.S. goods returned to the United States by its Armed Forces; personal and household effects of travelers; and in-transit shipments. Data for U.S. exports to Canada are derived from import data compiled by Canada. For more information on the data exchange and substitution please refer to the FT-900. The General Imports value reflects the total arrival of merchandise from foreign countries that immediately enters consumption channels, warehouses, or Foreign Trade Zones.

For imports, the value reported is the U.S. Customs and Border Protection appraised value of merchandise—generally, the price paid for merchandise for export to the United States. Import duties, freight, insurance, and other charges incurred in bringing merchandise to the United States are excluded.

Exports are valued at the free alongside ship value of merchandise at the U.S. port of export, based on the transaction price including inland freight, insurance, and other charges incurred in placing the merchandise alongside the carrier at the U.S. port of exportation.

Additional information on coverage and valuation are available in the Guide to Foreign Trade Statistics, <www.census.gov/foreign-trade/guide/sec2.html#coverage> and <www.census.gov/foreign-trade/guide/sec2.html#valuation>, respectively.

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Nonsampling Errors

Goods data are a complete enumeration of documents collected by the U.S. Customs and Border Protection and are not subject to sampling errors. This report presents current month statistics which reflect nearly complete coverage. Current month statistics reflecting complete coverage will be published in the upcoming U.S. International Trade in Goods and Services report (FT-900). Statistics for other months shown reflect complete coverage and appear in the most recently published FT-900. Quality assurance procedures are performed at every stage of collection, processing, and tabulation. However, the data are still subject to several types of nonsampling errors. Information on nonsampling errors and other quality issues are available in the Guide to Foreign Trade Statistics, <https://www.census.gov/foreign-trade/guide/sec2.html#error>.

The U.S. Census Bureau recommends that data users incorporate this information into their analyses, as nonsampling errors could impact the conclusion drawn from the results. For a detailed discussion of errors affecting the goods data, see U.S. Merchandise Trade Statistics: A Quality Profile (October 2014), available at <www.census.gov/foreign-trade/aip/quality_profile10032014.pdf> or from the Economic Indicators Division, U.S. Census Bureau.

Adjustments for Seasonal and Trading-Day Variations

Goods data are presented on a seasonally adjusted and not seasonally adjusted basis. Seasonally adjusted (and/or trading day adjusted data) are produced using X-13ARIMA-SEATS software to develop monthly adjustment factors. Goods data are initially classified under the Harmonized Commodity Description and Coding System (Harmonized System), which is an internationally accepted standard for the commodity classification of traded goods. Combining trade into approximately 140 export and 140 import end-use categories makes it possible to examine goods according to their principal uses. These categories are used as the basis for computing the seasonal and trading-day adjusted data. These adjusted data are then summed to the six end-use aggregates for publication.
For more information, visit the seasonal adjustment section of the Guide to Foreign Trade here: <www.census.gov/foreign-trade/guide/sec2.html#seasonal>.

Retail and Wholesale Inventories

National estimates of end-of-month inventories are based on data from the Monthly Retail Trade Survey and the Monthly Wholesale Trade Survey. Additional information for each survey can be found at <www.census.gov/retail> and <www.census.gov/wholesale>. The advance estimates contained in this report are not incorporated into the full MRTS and MWTS time series.

The MRTS and MWTS samples selected to measure inventories consist of a stratified simple random sampling method of approximately 11,000 retail firms and 4,200 wholesale firms located in the United States. The retail and wholesale samples include firms of all sizes and are updated on a quarterly basis to account for new retail and wholesale firms, deaths, and other changes to the universe.

Data for nonresponding firms are imputed based on data for similar-sized firms classified in the same kind of business. For surveyed Retail companies, approximately 35.7 percent provided data for this reporting period

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resulting in a total quantity response rate of 48.0 percent. For surveyed Wholesale companies, approximately 48.4 percent provided data for this reporting period resulting in a total quantity response rate of 51.1 percent.

MRTS estimates cover companies with one or more establishments that sell merchandise and related services to final consumers. The Census Bureau has reviewed this data product to ensure appropriate access, use, and disclosure avoidance protection of the confidential source data (Project No. P-7504206, Disclosure Review Board (DRB) approval number: CBDRB-FY26-003).

MWTS estimates cover wholesale merchants who sell goods on their own account and include such businesses as wholesale merchants or jobbers, industrial distributors, exporters, and importers. Sales offices and branches maintained by manufacturing, refining, or mining firms for the purpose of marketing their products are not covered in this report. Also excluded is NAICS Industry Group 4251: Wholesale Electronic Markets and Agents and Brokers. The Census Bureau has reviewed this data product to ensure appropriate access, use, and disclosure avoidance protection of the confidential source data (Project No. 7503922, Disclosure Review Board (DRB) approval number: CBDRB-FY26-005).

Reliability of Estimates

Because the retail and wholesale estimates are based on a sample survey, they contain sampling error and nonsampling error.

Sampling error is the difference between the estimate and the result that would be obtained from a complete enumeration of the sampling frame conducted under the same survey conditions. This error occurs because only a subset of the entire sampling frame is measured in a sample survey. Standard errors and coefficients of variation are estimated measures of sampling variation.

The margin of sampling error gives a range about the estimate which is a 90 percent confidence interval. If, for example, the percentage change estimate is +1.2 percent and its estimated standard error is 0.9 percent, then the margin of sampling error is ±1.753 x 0.9 percent or ±1.6 percent, and the 90 percent confidence interval is −0.4 percent to +2.8 percent. If the interval contains 0, then one does not have sufficient evidence to conclude at the 90 percent confidence level that the change is different from zero and therefore the change is not statistically significant. Estimated changes are statistically significant unless otherwise noted. For a monthly total, the estimated coefficient of variation is given. The resulting confidence interval is the estimated value ±1.753 x CV x (the estimated monthly total).

Nonsampling error encompasses all other factors that contribute to the total error of a sample survey estimate. This type of error can occur because of nonresponse, insufficient coverage of the universe of businesses, mistakes in the recording and coding of data, and other errors of collection, response, coverage, or processing. Although nonsampling error is not measured directly, the Census Bureau employs quality control procedures throughout the process to minimize this type of error.

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The U.S. Census Bureau recommends that individuals using retail and wholesale estimates incorporate this information into their analyses, as sampling error and nonsampling error could affect the conclusions drawn from the estimates.

Adjustments for Seasonal Variations

Concurrent seasonal adjustment is used to adjust the retail and wholesale inventories estimates for seasonal variations. Concurrent seasonal adjustment uses all available unadjusted estimates as input to the X-13ARIMA-SEATS program. The factors derived from the program are applied to the retail and wholesale estimates of current and previous month inventories and for inventories estimates a year ago as well.

Statement Regarding Natural Disasters: For information on the impact of natural disasters, including hurricanes, on the compilation of this report, please see <Wholesale Natural Disaster FAQs> and <Retail Natural Disaster FAQs>.

Data Availability

The Advance Economic Indicators Report is available at <www.census.gov/econ/indicators/index.html>. For archived versions of the Advance Economic Indicators Report please visit the Historical Data tab at the following: <www.census.gov/econ/indicators/historical_data.html>.

RESOURCES

API

The Census Bureau's application programming interface lets developers create custom apps to reach new users and makes key demographic, socio-economic and housing statistics more accessible than ever before. <www.census.gov/developers>

FRED Mobile App

Receive the latest updates on the nation's key economic indicators by downloading the FRED App <fred.stlouisfed.org/fred-mobile> for both Apple and Android devices. FRED, the signature database of the Federal Reserve Bank of St. Louis, now incorporates the Census Bureau's 13 economic indicators.

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*** The 90 percent confidence interval includes zero. There is insufficient statistical evidence to conclude that the actual change is different from zero.**

° Statistical significance is not applicable or not measurable for this survey.

(R) Revised from the last published Monthly Retail Trade Report and Monthly Wholesale Trade: Sales and Inventories Report

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Table 1. U.S. International Trade in Goods by Principal End-Use Category (1)

In millions of dollars. Details may not equal totals due to seasonal adjustment and rounding. (X) – Not applicable

	Goods - Census Basis (2)						
	Monthly				Percent change		
	September 2026 (a)	August 2026	July 2026	September 2025	September 2026/ August 2026	August 2026/ July 2026	September 2026/ September 2025
Seasonally Adjusted							
Balance	-134,904	-132,069	-118,856	-82,730	(X)	(X)	(X)
Exports	209,244	203,977	199,823	185,704	2.6	2.1	12.7
Foods, Feeds, & Beverages	16,008	14,187	15,031	13,812	12.8	-5.6	15.9
Industrial Supplies (3)	76,536	77,771	71,438	66,842	-1.6	8.9	14.5
Capital Goods	73,267	69,506	68,166	59,029	5.4	2.0	24.1
Automotive Vehicles, etc.	11,909	12,612	13,529	12,810	-5.6	-6.8	-7.0
Consumer Goods	22,217	20,868	23,035	24,930	6.5	-9.4	-10.9
Other Goods	9,307	9,033	8,626	8,281	3.0	4.7	12.4
Imports	344,148	336,046	318,679	268,435	2.4	5.4	28.2
Foods, Feeds, & Beverages	18,131	18,604	17,635	16,771	-2.5	5.5	8.1
Industrial Supplies (3)	58,935	62,665	53,535	49,450	-6.0	17.1	19.2
Capital Goods	157,362	146,427	140,274	88,821	7.5	4.4	77.2
Automotive Vehicles, etc.	34,285	35,724	35,393	33,495	-4.0	0.9	2.4
Consumer Goods	59,284	57,492	57,978	67,398	3.1	-0.8	-12.0
Other Goods	16,151	15,135	13,863	12,500	6.7	9.2	29.2
Not Seasonally Adjusted							
Balance	-145,525	-131,421	-135,420	-91,623	(X)	(X)	(X)
Exports	208,266	204,749	197,551	185,185	1.7	3.6	12.5
Foods, Feeds, & Beverages	14,657	13,264	13,585	13,197	10.5	-2.4	11.1
Industrial Supplies (3)	75,491	79,132	72,168	66,013	-4.6	9.6	14.4
Capital Goods	73,103	69,581	68,632	58,565	5.1	1.4	24.8
Automotive Vehicles, etc.	12,328	13,174	13,027	13,334	-6.4	1.1	-7.5
Consumer Goods	23,287	20,377	21,496	25,711	14.3	-5.2	-9.4
Other Goods	9,400	9,221	8,642	8,364	1.9	6.7	12.4
Imports	353,791	336,170	332,971	276,807	5.2	1.0	27.8
Foods, Feeds, & Beverages	17,115	17,969	17,613	16,051	-4.8	2.0	6.6
Industrial Supplies (3)	58,708	63,097	56,942	49,809	-7.0	10.8	17.9
Capital Goods	162,403	146,664	148,550	91,360	10.7	-1.3	77.8
Automotive Vehicles, etc.	34,207	36,205	35,463	33,656	-5.5	2.1	1.6
Consumer Goods	64,717	58,212	60,223	73,110	11.2	-3.3	-11.5
Other Goods	16,641	14,023	14,181	12,822	18.7	-1.1	29.8

(a) Advance statistics

(1) For a listing of the detail included in each end-use category, see <www.census.gov/foreign-trade/reference/codes/enduse/exeumstr.txt>.
(2) Data are presented on a Census basis. The information needed to convert to a balance of payment basis is not available.
(3) Includes petroleum and petroleum products.

NOTES:
* Current month statistics reflect nearly complete coverage; current month statistics reflecting complete coverage will be published in the upcoming U.S. International Trade in Goods and Services report (FT-900). Statistics for other months shown reflect complete coverage and appear in the most recently published FT-900.
* For information on data sources, nonsampling errors, and definitions, see the explanatory notes in this release or at <www.census.gov/econ/indicators/advance_report.pdf>.
Source: U.S. Census Bureau; Advance Economic Indicators Report, October 28, 2026.

Table 2. Levels and Percent Changes for Inventories

Inventories estimates are shown in millions of dollars. Estimates are based on data from the Monthly Wholesale Trade Survey and the Monthly Retail Trade Survey.

	Inventories					
	Monthly			Percent change		
	September 2026 (a)	August 2026 (r)	September 2025 (r)	September 2026/ August 2026	August 2026/ July 2026	September 2026/ September 2025
Adjusted[1]						
Merchant wholesale[2] trade, total	1,011,522	1,005,588	941,475	0.6	0.5	7.4
Durable goods	628,663	625,983	583,355	0.4	0.8	7.8
Nondurable goods	382,859	379,605	358,120	0.9	0.1	6.9
Retail[3] trade, total	885,327	882,331	844,641	0.3	0.3	4.8
Total (excl. motor veh. & parts)	608,005	605,621	581,999	0.4	0.1	4.5
Motor vehicle & parts dealers	277,322	276,710	262,642	0.2	0.7	5.6
Not Adjusted						
Merchant wholesale[2] trade, total	1,006,066	990,292	934,959	1.6	-0.1	7.6
Durable goods	632,768	629,519	586,839	0.5	0.5	7.8
Nondurable goods	373,298	360,773	348,120	3.5	-1.0	7.2
Retail[3] trade, total	900,242	872,150	857,938	3.2	0.4	4.9
Total (excl. motor veh. & parts)	623,320	601,380	596,349	3.6	0.7	4.5
Motor vehicle & parts dealers	276,922	270,770	261,589	2.3	-0.4	5.9

(a) Advance estimate
(r) Revised estimate

See footnotes and notes at the end of Table 3.

Table 3. Estimated Measures of Sampling Variability

Estimates are shown as percents and are based on data from the Monthly Wholesale Trade Survey and the Monthly Retail Trade Survey.

	Inventories					
	Monthly			Standard Error of		
	Coefficient of Variation			Percent Change		
	September 2026 (a)	August 2026 (r)	September 2025 (r)	September 2026/ August 2026	August 2026/ July 2026	September 2026/ September 2025
Merchant wholesale[2] trade, total	1.9	2.0	1.9	0.1	0.1	0.6
Durable goods	2.7	2.7	2.7	0.1	0.1	0.9
Nondurable goods	1.9	1.9	1.7	0.3	0.3	0.5
Retail trade, total	1.1	1.1	1.1	0.1	0.1	0.3
Total (excl. motor veh. & parts)	1.5	1.5	1.6	Z	Z	0.2
Motor vehicle & parts dealers	1.8	1.7	1.6	0.2	0.1	0.8

(a) Advance estimate
(r) Revised estimate
Z Estimate rounds to zero

(1) Estimates are concurrently adjusted for seasonal variation and trading day differences, but not for price changes. Concurrent seasonal adjustment uses all available not adjusted estimates as input to the X-13ARIMA-SEATS program. The factors derived from the program are used in calculating all seasonally adjusted estimates shown in this table.

(2) The 2017 North American Industry Classification System (NAICS) defines merchant wholesalers as including manufacturers' sales branches and offices. However, the estimates included in this release exclude manufacturers' sales branches and offices. Note that this is not a change in coverage from prior releases and is consistent with the description used in the Monthly Wholesale Trade Survey data products.

(3) Retail Trade estimates include data only for businesses with paid employees. Prior to the benchmark report released in April 2025, the monthly retail estimates that were released in the Advance Economic Indicators Report estimates included nonemployers.

NOTES:
Estimated measures of sampling variability are based on estimates not adjusted for seasonal variation. Additional information on confidentiality protection, sampling error, nonsampling error, sample design, and definitions may be found at <www.census.gov/wholesale/www/how_surveys_are_collected/monthly_methodology.html> for wholesale and at <www.census.gov/retail/mrts/how_surveys_are_collected.html> for retail.

Source: U.S. Census Bureau; Advance Economic Indicators Report, October 28, 2026.